mind are preposterous, malicious and incorrect, to say the least. More seriously, these are loaded with dangerous portents that can play havoc with the secular and apolitical fabric of the great institution that we have given the best part of our lives to, and also cause incalculable harm to the nation as well. In fact, during my tenure as the COAS from 1 February 2005 to 30 September 2007, there was no controversy on this matter at all. In 2006, as the army chief, I recommended V.K. Singh (then major general) to be GOC 2 Corps, one of our strike corps, which is considered a prize assignment, so as to give him the requisite experience of handling large mechanised formations. Besides, in 2005, I had taken him with me on my first official visit abroad to Oman and the UK. Thus such insinuations at this stage by some of the army chief's advisers or 'well-wishers' have deeply appalled and angered me. Furthermore, in a recent interview with a magazine, he himself has implied motives regarding the decision of the Army HQ on his age issue.

I had so far maintained a stoic silence on the unfortunate controversy as the matter was sub-judice. However, the deliberations and the sagacious judgement of the Supreme Court on the army chief's petition, said it all. There are many who feel that in a personal matter such as this, the case should have been handled with the utmost discretion, sans the unsavoury media hype. What is certain is that the organization that we cherish so much has lost a lot of its sheen. A challenge every chief faces is his responsibility towards the future of his service; this was my main concern and I did not allow anything to come in the way during my tenure as COAS or later.

Unfortunately, the matter was once again raised with a vicious spin by filing a motivated and an utterly malicious public interest litigation (PIL) before the Supreme Court, raising the 'communal angle' and some allegations against the army chief-designate. This irresponsible and mischievous plan was nipped in the bud on 23 April 2012 by the curt dismissal of the PIL by the apex court as the honourable bench saw through the nefarious design of the the complainants, thereby vindicating the stand of the government. This entire episode has left a sour taste and vitiated the environment of